

# PART 3: USER, PROBLEM & DISCOVERY MASTERY

If you remember nothing else from this book, remember this: **the difference between mediocre PMs and great ones is not their solutions; it is their problems.** Mediocre PMs solve poorly-defined problems brilliantly. Great PMs solve well-defined problems competently. The second produces vastly more value.

This chapter teaches the craft of finding, defining, and validating problems. It is the most undervalued skill in product management and the highest-leverage one to master early.

## 3.1 What a "User Problem" Really Is

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Junior PMs use the word "problem" loosely. In PM craft, a *user problem* has a specific, narrow definition:

A user problem is a **gap between what a user wants their life to be and what their current options let it be**, that is **important enough to motivate them to seek a solution**, and **frequent enough to matter**.

Three components, each non-negotiable:

1. **A gap between desired and actual state.** "I want to be productive" is a desired state. "I currently lose 3 hours a week looking for files" is the gap. Both are needed; one without the other is incomplete.
2. **Importance.** The user must care enough to do something. People have hundreds of vague desires; only a few translate into action.
3. **Frequency.** A problem that occurs once a year may not be a viable product opportunity even if individually painful. A problem that occurs every day, even if individually mild, can be a great opportunity.

If you can't articulate all three components for your problem, you don't have one yet — you have a hunch.

### Worked Example: Distinguishing real problems from non-problems

A user says, "I wish I could change the font in your app."

- **Gap:** Their content looks fine in current font; they just have a stylistic preference.
- **Importance:** Mild. They didn't pay extra; they didn't churn; they just wished it were different.

- **Frequency:** Probably once or twice during the entire customer relationship.

This is **not a real problem**. It's a preference. A naive PM hears this, codes it as "users want font customization," and ships it. A trained PM sets it aside.

Compare this:

A user says, "I keep losing track of which version of a document is the latest. I've sent the wrong version to clients twice this month."

- **Gap:** Wants confidence about current version; doesn't have it.
- **Importance:** High — embarrassed in front of clients.
- **Frequency:** "Twice this month" — recurring.

This is a **real problem**. Worth investigating deeply.

## 3.2 Problem vs Solution vs Feature: The Three Layers

PMs constantly confuse these three things, and that confusion is the #1 reason teams build the wrong things. Let's separate them precisely.

| Layer           | Definition                                        | Example                                                           |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Problem</b>  | The user's gap (what they want vs what they have) | "I lose track of file versions and embarrass myself with clients" |
| <b>Solution</b> | An approach to closing that gap                   | "Auto-versioning with a clear 'current version' indicator"        |
| <b>Feature</b>  | The specific implementation of that solution      | "A green badge on the latest file with version history modal"     |

Many problems can be solved by many solutions. Each solution can have many features. The PM's job is to map this whole tree, then choose the smallest, simplest *feature* that closes the *real problem*.

**The cardinal sin** is to skip from problem to feature without naming the solution layer. This produces feature factories: PMs handed feature requests, PMs shipping features, with no one asking "what solution does this feature implement, and is that the right solution?"

### Solution-thinking practice

For each problem below, list at least 3 different *solutions*, then for one of them, list at least 2 different *features* that could implement it.

**Problem:** "I lose track of which document version is the latest."

Possible solutions:

1. Make versions invisible (always one canonical version, history hidden)

2. Make versions auto-named with metadata (timestamp + author + change summary)
3. Make versions branch-and-merge (Git-style)

For solution #1, possible features:

- Hide all version history; show only "last edit by X at Y time"
- Auto-archive old versions to a "history" folder accessed only on request

Notice that the difference between Google Docs (solution #1: there's only one document, history is implicit) and Microsoft Word (multiple files, manual versioning) is fundamentally a different *solution* to the same *problem*.

Mastering this layered thinking is the single biggest mental shift between a junior and a senior PM.

## 3.3 The Jobs-To-Be-Done (JTBD) Framework — Comprehensive

JTBD is the most powerful framework for thinking about user motivation. It comes from Clayton Christensen (Harvard) and has been refined by Tony Ulwick, Bob Moesta, and others. There are subtle disagreements between schools of JTBD, but the core insight is identical:

People don't buy products. They "hire" products to make progress in their lives. The job is the progress they're trying to make. Different jobs can lead to the same product purchase. Different products can compete for the same job.

### The Milkshake Example (canonical)

Christensen consulted for a fast-food chain trying to grow milkshake sales. Initial approach: surveys asking "what would make our milkshakes better?" Customers said "thicker," "more chocolate," "fruit chunks." The chain implemented these. Sales didn't move.

Christensen's team then watched buyers. Two distinct purchase patterns emerged:

- **Morning customers (commuters):** Bought milkshakes alone, took them in the car. Goal: a long, viscous, one-handed snack to make a boring 30-minute commute tolerable while keeping them full until lunch.
- **Afternoon customers (parents):** Bought milkshakes for kids. Goal: a treat that signals "good parent" without a fight, easy to clean up, healthy enough to feel okay about.

The same product was being hired for two completely different jobs. The morning shake's competitors were donuts and coffee, not other milkshakes. The afternoon shake competed with cookies and ice cream. Improving the milkshake required different actions for each job:

- For commuters: thicker (lasts longer), more interesting (snack-ier), easier to drink while driving.

- For parents: smaller, less messy, healthier-seeming.

A single "improvement" that ignored job context made everyone unhappy.

## Anatomy of a Job Statement

A well-written job statement has this structure:

*When [SITUATION], I want to [MOTIVATION], so I can [EXPECTED OUTCOME].*

Examples:

- "When I'm commuting alone in the morning and won't have time for breakfast, I want something filling and engaging, so I can avoid hunger and boredom for 30 minutes."
- "When my client texts me about a deal change, I want to instantly find the right contract version, so I can respond confidently without making a mistake."
- "When my team is debating priorities in standup, I want to show data on which projects are blocking which deals, so I can resolve the debate with evidence rather than opinion."

Notice the structure forces you to specify:

- **The trigger** (situation): when does the job arise?
- **The desire** (motivation): what do they want to do?
- **The success criterion** (outcome): how do they know they've succeeded?

If you can't fill in all three, you don't yet understand the job. Go back to the user.

## Functional, Emotional, and Social Jobs

Every product hiring decision involves three layers of jobs:

1. **Functional job:** The objective task. *"Get to work fast."*
2. **Emotional job:** How the user wants to feel. *"Feel in control during my morning."*
3. **Social job:** How the user wants others to perceive them. *"Be seen as someone who has it together."*

People rarely articulate emotional and social jobs because they're embarrassing or unconscious. A great PM uncovers them through observation, not direct questioning.

Example: a B2B SaaS user wanting a beautiful dashboard isn't *just* hiring it for "data visibility." They're also hiring it for "look professional in front of my boss" (emotional/social). A PM who designs only for the functional job will lose to a competitor who serves all three.

## Outcome-Based Job Mapping (Tony Ulwick's School)

Ulwick's "Outcome-Driven Innovation" extends JTBD into a practical research method. The steps:

1. **Identify the core job-to-be-done** (in customer terms, not solution terms).

2. **Break it into job steps** — the sequence of mini-jobs from start to finish.
3. **For each step, identify desired outcomes** — measurable success criteria the user wants to achieve.
4. **Score each outcome on importance and current satisfaction** with existing solutions.
5. **Find the underserved outcomes** — high importance, low satisfaction. These are the *opportunities*.

Example for "Manage personal finances":

| Job step       | Desired outcome                        | Importance | Current satisfaction | Opportunity score |
|----------------|----------------------------------------|------------|----------------------|-------------------|
| Track spending | Categorize transactions automatically  | 9          | 4                    | 14                |
| Track spending | See spending trends over time          | 8          | 6                    | 10                |
| Plan budget    | Set realistic budgets based on history | 9          | 3                    | 15                |
| Plan budget    | Get alerted before overspending        | 9          | 5                    | 13                |
| Save           | Automate savings transfers             | 7          | 7                    | 7                 |
| Invest         | Get personalized investment advice     | 6          | 4                    | 8                 |

(Opportunity score = Importance + max(0, Importance – Satisfaction))

The high-opportunity outcomes ("set realistic budgets based on history" — score 15) tell you where to invest. The low-opportunity ones ("automate savings" — score 7) are well-served and not worth your effort.

This is the most rigorous form of JTBD discovery and is widely used at companies like Mint, Bosch, and Microsoft for new-feature ideation. We'll come back to opportunity scoring in Part 5 (Prioritization).

## 3.4 Personas — When They Help, When They Hurt

Personas are simplified, archetypal user descriptions used to ground product decisions. Done well, they're useful. Done poorly, they're a waste of time.

### A Bad Persona

**"Marketing Mary"** Age 32, lives in a major city, drinks lattes, married, two kids, drives a Subaru, loves yoga.

This is fluff. None of these details affect product decisions. You will not build a feature differently because Mary loves yoga. The persona has demographic detail that *doesn't drive design*.

## A Good Persona

### Mary, Mid-Market Marketing Manager

*Job context:* Marketing manager at a 200-person SaaS company. Reports to a VP of Marketing. Has 2 direct reports. Quarterly OKRs include "demo requests grown by X" and "marketing-attributed revenue grown by Y."

*Workflow:* Spends ~40% of week running campaigns, ~30% in tools (CRM, analytics, design), ~20% in meetings, ~10% reporting up.

*Tools she uses daily:* HubSpot, Salesforce, Figma (lightly), Google Analytics, Slack, Notion. Lives in HubSpot.

*Frequent jobs:*

1. Run a campaign end-to-end (plan → execute → measure)
2. Justify ROI to her VP weekly
3. Report on campaign performance to broader team

*Frustrations:* Tools don't talk to each other. She manually reconciles data in spreadsheets every Friday. Her VP asks ad hoc questions she can't answer fast.

*What "winning" looks like for her:* Hitting OKRs without working weekends. Getting promoted to Director within 18 months.

*What success looks like for our product:* Mary uses our product without thinking — it's part of her toolchain, not a separate thing she "logs into."

This is useful. Every line drives product decisions. Notice it includes:

- **Job context** — what's her actual situation?
- **Workflow** — how does she spend her time?
- **Tool ecosystem** — what does our product live alongside?
- **Frequent jobs** — what does she do repeatedly?
- **Frustrations** — where can we add value?
- **Definition of personal success** — what's her career incentive?
- **Definition of product success** — what does usage look like?

The principle: **a persona is useful if and only if it changes the product decisions you make.**

## When Personas Hurt

Personas can be dangerous when:

- They're built from imagination, not data. Fictional personas mislead the team.
- They're treated as "the user" rather than "one user archetype." Every product has multiple personas; pretending there's only one ("the user") is a lie that hides important segment differences.
- They're not updated as the product evolves. The persona you wrote 18 months ago may no longer match your actual users.

A modern alternative: **JTBD-based segmentation** — segment users by the job they're hiring your product for, not by demographic. Your "morning commute milkshake" buyers and your "treat for the kid" buyers may have identical demographics but very different jobs.

## 3.5 User Journey Mapping

A user journey map traces the full sequence of steps a user takes to accomplish a job, including their emotions, pain points, and "moments of truth" along the way.

### Anatomy of a Journey Map

| Stage         | What user does                   | What they think           | What they feel      | Pain points      | Opportunities  |
|---------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------|------------------|----------------|
| Awareness     | Realizes they have a problem     | "I keep missing meetings" | Frustrated          | No system        | Aware of need  |
| Consideration | Evaluates options                | "What apps do this?"      | Overwhelmed         | Choice paralysis | Recommendation |
| Trial         | Signs up, tries it               | "Is this any easier?"     | Skeptical, hopeful  | Setup friction   | Quick win      |
| Adoption      | Uses regularly for first 2 weeks | "Saving me time?"         | Relieved or annoyed | Habit not formed | Onboarding     |
| Habit         | Embedded in daily life           | Doesn't think about it    | Trusts it           | Edge cases       | Power features |
| Advocacy      | Recommends to others             | "You should try this"     | Proud               | Privacy concern  | Referral loop  |

A journey map forces you to think beyond a single feature into the full user lifecycle. **Pain points cluster at transitions** — between "considering" and "trying," between "adoption" and "habit." These transitions are where most users drop off.

Many products have great mid-journey UX but lousy onboarding (lose users at the trial→adoption transition) or great onboarding but no advocacy loop (lose users at the habit→advocacy transition). A journey map makes these gaps visible.

## Tools for Journey Mapping

- A whiteboard (the cheapest and often best).
- Miro, FigJam, Mural for distributed teams. ([miro.com](https://miro.com))
- Sketch in a Notion table or Google Sheet — it doesn't have to be pretty to be useful.

## Practice: Map a journey for an Indian app

Pick any app you use (e.g., Swiggy, PhonePe, Zerodha, Cred). Map the user journey for one specific job (e.g., "ordering dinner on a Friday night," "splitting a bill with friends"). Use the columns above. Identify three pain points and three opportunities.

This is one of the most valuable practice exercises you can do daily. We'll do guided teardowns of major products in Part 14.

## 3.6 The User Interview — Craft of the Trade

User interviews are the single most important skill in product discovery. They are also the most commonly mishandled.

The two most common mistakes:

1. **Asking what users want** ("Would you use a feature that...?"). Users don't know what they want until they see it. They give socially desirable answers.
2. **Pitching the solution** ("So we're thinking about adding X. What do you think?"). The user becomes a critic of your idea instead of a teacher about their life.

The right approach: **never ask about the future. Always ask about the past.** The past is real; the future is fantasy. Stories of past behavior reveal real motivations; opinions about future features reveal nothing useful.

### The Mom Test (Rob Fitzpatrick)

Rob Fitzpatrick's *The Mom Test* is the canonical reference. The core idea: ask questions so concrete that even your mom couldn't lie to give you good news.

**Bad question:** "Do you think this idea is good?" (*Your mom will say yes regardless.*) **Better question:** "What was the last time you tried to do X?"

**Bad question:** "Would you pay for this?" (*People say yes to imaginary purchases all the time.*) **Better question:** "What have you paid for in this space recently? How much?"

**Bad question:** "Would you find this useful?" (*Anyone is polite enough to say yes.*) **Better question:** "Walk me through the last time you had this problem. What did you do? How did it go?"

The pattern: turn every question about the future or hypothetical into a question about a specific past event.



## Question Design — A Working Library

Memorize these question patterns. They are the heart of qualitative research.

### To uncover real workflows:

- "Walk me through the last time you [did X]. Start from the beginning."
- "What were you doing right before that?"
- "Then what happened?"
- "If something went wrong, what was it?"
- "What did you do next?"

### To uncover pain:

- "What's the most frustrating part of your week?"
- "When was the last time you got really annoyed at [tool/process]?"
- "What's something you've complained about to a coworker recently?"

### To uncover spend / commitment:

- "Have you tried other tools for this? What worked, what didn't?"
- "What did you pay for [related solution] last year?"
- "If you could only keep three tools you use today, what would they be?"

### To uncover desired outcomes:

- "If we waved a magic wand and your [process] worked perfectly, what would that look like?"
- "What's success in your role measured by? How are you doing on those metrics?"

### To uncover competitive landscape:

- "Who else have you considered for this? Why didn't you pick them?"
- "What would have to change for you to switch from your current solution?"

### To dig deeper (these are gold):

- "Why?" (asked gently, multiple times; the 5-Whys technique)
- "Tell me more about that."
- *Silence.* (The most underrated question. Wait. Users will fill the gap with deeper truth.)

## Questions to Avoid

These produce noise, not signal:

- "Would you...?" (hypothetical future)
- "Do you think...?" (opinion, not behavior)
- "If we built X, would you use it?" (the user has no idea)
- "How important is X to you on a scale of 1-10?" (people give socially desirable answers)

- Leading questions: "Don't you think it would be great if...?"
- Compound questions: "When you log in, do you find it confusing or unintuitive?" (forces a yes/no on two different things)

## A Sample Interview Script

Here's a 30-minute script for a SaaS product discovery interview. Adapt to your context:

### INTRO (3 min)

- Thank them for time. Brief context (you're researching, not pitching).
- Ask permission to record.
- Set expectations: "I'm going to ask about your work; not pitching anything."

### WARMUP (2 min)

- "Tell me about your role and team."
- "What does a typical day look like for you?"

### CORE WORKFLOW (10 min) – discover the actual job

- "Walk me through the last time you [did X – the relevant task]. Start from the very beginning."
- Don't interrupt. Let them tell the story. Take notes on emotions, friction points, decisions.
- After they finish, probe: "When you said you got frustrated at the [step], what was happening exactly?"
- "What did you do then?"

### ALTERNATIVES & TRADE-OFFS (5 min)

- "Have you tried other tools for this?"
- "What works about your current approach? What doesn't?"
- "If your current tool disappeared tomorrow, what would you do?"

### WISH-LIST (5 min) – but careful, don't accept literal answers

- "If you could change anything about how this works, what would it be?"
- (Don't take answers literally; treat them as symptoms. Probe: "Why would that help? What would change?")

### CLOSE (2 min)

- "Anything else I should have asked but didn't?"
- "Would you be open to a follow-up if I have more questions?"
- Thank them again.

### POST-INTERVIEW (10 min – solo)

- Within 1 hour, write up: their job, the steps, the pain points, the surprises, what changed your mind, what your next research question is.

## Number of Interviews — How Many is Enough?

Common heuristic: **5-7 interviews per persona / segment** is enough to spot patterns.

Diminishing returns set in around 8-12 for any one segment. After that, you're confirming what you already know — go interview a *different* segment, or move to quantitative research.

For a major new initiative, plan **15-25 interviews** total, split across 2-3 segments.

## After the Interview: Synthesis

Raw interview transcripts are useless. The real work is synthesis. Two methods that work well:

**Affinity mapping:**

- Write each insight on a sticky (digital or physical).
- Group related insights into clusters.
- Name each cluster.
- Note the strongest, most specific quotes per cluster.

**Top jobs / top frustrations / top quotes:**

- Across all interviews, what are the top 3 jobs users described?
- What are the top 3 frustrations?
- What are the 5 most striking quotes that capture the truth of users' experience?

In Part 11, we'll show how to use AI to dramatically speed up synthesis.

**A Library of Bad Questions and Their Repairs**

| Bad question                            | Why it fails                                   | Repair                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Would you use a feature that did X?"   | Asks about future / hypothetical               | "When was the last time you needed something like X? What did you do?"     |
| "What features would you add?"          | User isn't a designer; gives uninformed wishes | "What's the most painful part of your current workflow?"                   |
| "How important is speed to you?"        | Everyone says "very"                           | "Tell me about a time speed mattered. What happened?"                      |
| "Do you find our app easy to use?"      | Politeness bias                                | "Walk me through the last time you used our app. Where did you get stuck?" |
| "Would you pay \$20/month for this?"    | People lie about future spend                  | "What do you currently pay for tools in this space?"                       |
| "Don't you think it'd be useful if...?" | Leading                                        | "What's missing from your current setup?"                                  |

**3.7 Quantitative Research — Surveys and Analytics**

Qualitative research (interviews) tells you *why*. Quantitative research tells you *how many* and *how often*. Both are needed. PMs who skip quantitative are operating on stories; PMs who skip qualitative are operating on patterns they don't understand.

**Surveys — Done Right**

Surveys work for: validating that a pattern uncovered in interviews holds across a larger population; tracking metrics over time (NPS, CSAT); segmenting your user base.

Surveys fail when: they ask about future behavior; they're too long; they're sent to the wrong segment.

### Question design rules:

- Keep it under 5 minutes. Aim for 7–10 questions max for high response rates.
- Use mostly past-tense, behavioral questions. ("In the last month, how often did you...")
- Avoid leading wording.
- Pre-test on 5 real users before sending broadly.

### Common useful surveys:

- **NPS (Net Promoter Score):** "On a scale of 0–10, how likely are you to recommend X?"  
Plus a follow-up: "Why?" The follow-up is the value; the number is just the bucket.
- **CSAT (Customer Satisfaction):** "How satisfied are you with [specific interaction]?"  
Best used right after a specific touchpoint (e.g., post-onboarding, post-support).
- **PMF Score (Sean Ellis):** "How would you feel if you could no longer use our product?"  
Options: Very disappointed / Somewhat / Not. If 40%+ say "very disappointed," you have product-market fit. ([Sean Ellis blog](#))
- **Onboarding survey:** "What was your goal in signing up?" / "What did you hope to do today?" — captures the JTBD at the moment of signup.

## Analytics — The PM's Daily Practice

Behavioral analytics tells you what users actually *do*, free of self-report bias. The basics every PM must know:

- **Activity metrics:** DAU, MAU, sessions/user, time-in-app.
- **Conversion funnels:** What % of users complete each step from signup → activation → core action → revenue?
- **Retention curves:** Of users who signed up in week W, what % are still active in week W+1, W+2, ..., W+12?
- **Feature usage:** Which features are used by which segments? What's the adoption curve?
- **Cohorts:** Users grouped by signup date or attribute, tracked over time.

We'll dive deep into all of these in Part 7. For now, internalize: **a PM who can't read their own product's analytics is flying blind**, and **a PM who reads only analytics without ever talking to users is reading patterns they don't understand**. Both are needed; neither is enough.

## 3.8 Observation — The Lost Skill

Watching users use your product (without intervention, without leading) is a research method most teams skip. It's invaluable.

**Methods:**

- **Usability testing:** Give a user a task, watch them try to complete it. Take notes on where they hesitate, what they click on, what they say aloud (use the "think-aloud" protocol).
- **Field studies:** Visit users in their natural environment. Watch them work. Especially powerful for B2B (visit a salesperson during their day) or for emerging-market consumer (visit a Tier-2 city user at home).
- **Session recordings:** Tools like FullStory, Hotjar, LogRocket let you watch users navigate your product. Don't watch in isolation — pair with analytics to find segments worth watching.
- **Diary studies:** Users journal their experiences over a week or month. Useful for capturing emotion and context analytics can't see.

**A note on ethics:** Users must consent. Anonymize data. Don't watch session recordings of identified users without explicit permission. Recording laws vary by region (especially in EU under GDPR).

## 3.9 The Discovery Process — End to End

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Here's a complete, repeatable discovery process. Follow it for any major new initiative.

### Phase 1: Frame the Problem (Week 1)

- Articulate the problem hypothesis in writing.
- Identify the user segment(s) most likely to have this problem.
- Identify what data you already have (analytics, support tickets, sales feedback).
- Define what "yes, this is a real problem" looks like (specific evidence threshold).

### Phase 2: Existing-Data Sweep (Week 1-2)

Before talking to users, mine what you already have:

- Customer support tickets — search for keywords related to the problem.
- Sales call notes / Gong recordings — what objections come up?
- Existing user surveys — past NPS comments, churn surveys.
- Forums, Reddit, app store reviews, Twitter mentions.
- Competitor reviews, especially negative ones — they reveal unmet needs.

You'll often find that you already know the answer; you just hadn't synthesized.

### Phase 3: Generative Research (Weeks 2-4)

Conduct 8–15 user interviews aimed at *learning*, not validating. Use the question patterns in 3.6.

Key principle: **interview for diversity of insight, not numerical sample size.** Five interviews with five different segments reveal more than 50 with one segment.

Synthesize. Build a JTBD map, journey map, persona update, and pain-point ranking.

## Phase 4: Hypothesis Formation (Week 4-5)

Translate insights into testable hypotheses. Use the format from Part 2:

"We believe [SOMETHING] because [EVIDENCE]. If we [DO X], then [Y WILL HAPPEN]. We will know we're right when [METRIC]."

## Phase 5: Validation (Weeks 5-8)

For each hypothesis, define the cheapest test:

- **Concept test:** Show 5-10 users a low-fidelity mockup, ask them to react. ("How does this match what you do today? What would change?")
- **Smoke test:** Build a landing page describing the feature; measure signups.
- **Wizard of Oz:** Manually do the feature for 3-5 customers, see if it actually solves their problem before automating.
- **Painted door:** Add a button in your existing product that goes to a "coming soon" page; measure click rate to gauge demand.

The output of this phase: validated or invalidated hypotheses. **Invalidation is success too** — it saves you from building the wrong thing.

## Phase 6: Decision (Week 8)

Based on phases 1-5, decide:

- **Build:** Hypothesis is validated; user need is real; market is sized; we have the resources.
- **Don't build (yet):** Need is real but not big enough; or we lack the right team; or strategic priorities shifted.
- **Build differently:** The need is real but our hypothesized solution was wrong. Iterate the solution.

The discipline of completing all six phases for a major initiative is what separates real product teams from feature factories.

## 3.10 Identifying Real Problems vs Superficial Feature Requests

This is the most practical skill in this chapter. Apply it daily.

When a stakeholder, customer, or executive says "we need to add X," do not start with "okay" or "no." Start with these questions:

1. **"What's the underlying problem this would solve?"** Force them to articulate the problem layer.
2. **"For whom?"** Specific segment, not "users."
3. **"How often does this come up?"** Frequency check.
4. **"How are people currently solving it?"** Understand the workaround.
5. **"What's the cost of *not* solving it?"** Severity check.
6. **"How would we know this solved the problem?"** Define success.

If the requestor cannot answer questions 1–5 specifically, the request is a feature looking for a problem — and probably not worth prioritizing yet. Send them back to do more discovery.

Worked example:

**CEO:** "We need to add a Slack integration." **You:** "What's the underlying problem you've heard about?" **CEO:** "Sales team mentioned it on the call yesterday." **You:** "Got it. Did they say what they wished they could do that they currently can't?" **CEO:** "They wanted to know about new signups in real time, in their main work tool." **You:** "So the underlying problem is that real-time signup awareness is hidden in our app, where they don't live. The Slack integration is one solution. Another could be email digests, mobile push notifications, or a webhook to whatever they use. Slack is the right answer if the sales team lives in Slack — do they? Or do they actually live in HubSpot or Salesforce?" **CEO:** "Hmm, mostly HubSpot." **You:** "Then a HubSpot integration may serve them better. Let me confirm with three sales reps before we commit."

This is the work. Most "feature requests" dissolve under questioning into different (often better, sometimes smaller) solutions. PMs who can do this conversation calmly and respectfully are infinitely valuable.

## 3.11 Mini Case Study #1: Airbnb's Discovery That Saved the Company

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In 2009, Airbnb was failing. Revenue was flat at ~\$200/week despite years of work. The founders couldn't figure out why.

Joe Gebbia decided to visit hosts in New York personally. He looked at their listings on the platform and realized something obvious in retrospect: **the photos were terrible**. Hosts were taking grainy, dark, phone-camera shots of their apartments. Listings looked like crime scenes. Of course no one was booking.

The team rented a \$5,000 camera and flew to New York to professionally photograph every Airbnb listing in the city. Within a week, revenue in New York doubled. Within a month, it was 4×.

This led to the development of Airbnb's "Photo Program" — they hired professional photographers to shoot listings free for hosts.

**The lesson** isn't "fix bad photos." It's that the founders got out of the office, watched users, and noticed what no analytics dashboard would have shown. The pattern was qualitative, not quantitative. It required physical presence. The book *The Airbnb Story* by Leigh Gallagher tells this story and many others; it's required reading for any aspiring PM.

**The PM takeaway:** In ambiguous problems, *go and look*. Visit users where they live and work. The most important truths about your product are rarely in your dashboard.

## 3.12 Mini Case Study #2: Superhuman's "Product/Market Fit" Question

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Rahul Vohra, founder of Superhuman, faced a question all founders face: do we have product/market fit yet, and how do we know? He found Sean Ellis's PMF question ("How would you feel if you could no longer use the product?") and built a system around it:

1. Sent the question to all active users.
2. Segmented: "very disappointed" (the proxy for PMF), "somewhat disappointed," "not disappointed."
3. For the "very disappointed" group, identified what they had in common — same role, same workflow, same description of the value.
4. Built relentlessly for *that* segment, even at the cost of de-prioritizing requests from other groups.
5. Tracked the % of users in the "very disappointed" bucket over time as the north star of PMF.

Superhuman went from ~22% "very disappointed" to ~58% in 18 months by following this process. This is now known as the "Superhuman PMF Engine," and Rahul wrote a famous essay on it. ([First Round Review](#))

**The PM takeaway:** PMF is not a binary you achieve once. It's a metric you can measure, track, and engineer. Superhuman's discipline of asking *the same question* and tracking the answer *over time* is a model worth copying.

## 3.13 Strong vs Weak Problem Statements

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A problem statement is the formal, written articulation of the user problem. It shows up at the top of every PRD, every design brief, every roadmap planning doc. Mastering its craft is essential.



## A Weak Problem Statement

"Users want a better way to manage their tasks."

Why it's weak: Vague. Who are "users"? What's "better"? What's "a way"? What's the cost of *not* solving this? It can't be tested or measured.

## A Stronger Problem Statement

"Marketing managers at companies of 50-500 employees waste 4+ hours per week reconciling task lists across email, Slack, Notion, and their head, leading to missed deadlines (reported by 60% of our 30 interviewees) and Sunday-night work catch-up. They've tried but abandoned 2-3 task tools because the tools don't fit their actual cross-channel workflow."

Why it's better:

- Specific user segment (marketing managers, mid-market).
- Quantified pain (4+ hours/week).
- Sourced (60% of 30 interviewees).
- Names the failed alternatives (gives context for why this isn't trivial).
- Implies a measurable success criterion (hours saved, weekend work avoided).

## Problem Statement Template

[USER SEGMENT] currently experiences [FRICTION/PAIN] when [SITUATION/JOB].  
This causes [CONSEQUENCE], which we know because [EVIDENCE].  
They have tried [ALTERNATIVES], but those fail because [LIMITATIONS].  
Solving this would mean [SUCCESS DEFINITION], measured by [METRIC].

Use this template until it becomes second nature. Then evolve it.

## 3.14 Comprehensive Practice — Discovery Exercises

### Exercise 3.1 — Job Discovery

Pick a product you use weekly (e.g., Spotify, Swiggy, LinkedIn). Write 3 different job statements you've personally hired it for, using the "When [situation] I want [motivation] so I can [outcome]" structure. Then identify which of those jobs the product serves best, which it serves worst, and which a competitor would serve better.

## Exercise 3.2 — Bad Question Repair

Review this list of 10 questions. Mark which are bad and rewrite each:

1. "Do you think AI features would be useful?"
2. "Walk me through the last time you used Notion to plan a project."
3. "Would you pay \$30/month for our pro plan?"
4. "What do you currently use for note-taking, and what works/doesn't?"
5. "Don't you find email overwhelming?"
6. "Tell me about a time you got really frustrated at your tools."
7. "How important is collaboration on a 1-10 scale?"
8. "What's your job and what tools do you use daily?"
9. "If we built a new chat feature, would you use it?"
10. "What were you trying to do right before you signed up?"

## Exercise 3.3 — Build a Persona from Interviews

Conduct 3 short interviews (15-30 min each) with people who use a product you're studying. Synthesize into one persona using the "Marketing Mary" template above. Bring real, sourced details only.

## Exercise 3.4 — Strong Problem Statement

For a real product you'd like to build (or improve), write a problem statement using the template in 3.13. Have a friend who is your target user evaluate: "Does this describe my situation?"

## Exercise 3.5 — Discovery Plan

You're a new PM at a hypothetical Indian fintech startup. The CEO says "we want to build a wealth management product for Tier 2/3 cities." Write a 2-page discovery plan covering:

- The hypothesis you'd test
- The user segments you'd interview
- 5 example interview questions
- What existing data you'd review first
- What "yes, build" vs "no, kill" would look like

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## Solutions

### Solution 3.2 (Bad question repair):

| #  | Verdict | Why / Repair                                                                                                                              |
|----|---------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Bad     | Hypothetical, future tense. Repair: "Have you tried any AI features in tools you use? Walk me through that experience."                   |
| 2  | Good    | Past, specific, opens story.                                                                                                              |
| 3  | Bad     | Hypothetical pricing question. Repair: "What do you currently pay for productivity tools, and how do you decide what's worth paying for?" |
| 4  | Good    | Past, behavioral, with reasoning probe.                                                                                                   |
| 5  | Bad     | Leading. Repair: "Walk me through how you handle email on a typical day. What works, what's frustrating?"                                 |
| 6  | Good    | Past, emotion-anchored.                                                                                                                   |
| 7  | Bad     | Self-report scale. Repair: "Tell me about a time collaboration on a project went well. Tell me about a time it didn't."                   |
| 8  | Good    | Warmup; sets context.                                                                                                                     |
| 9  | Bad     | Hypothetical. Repair: "When was the last time you used a chat tool for work? What was happening? What worked or didn't?"                  |
| 10 | Good    | Captures the JTBD at signup moment.                                                                                                       |

### **Solution 3.5 (Discovery plan for fintech):**

*Discovery plan: Wealth management for Indian Tier 2/3 users*

*Hypothesis to test:* "Tier 2/3 working professionals in India (HHI ₹5–25L) want to grow their savings beyond FDs and gold but feel that current wealth-management products are designed for English-speaking metro users with high investable amounts, leaving them without trustworthy options."

*User segments to interview (15–20 total):*

- First-time investors (just started saving, ₹50K–₹2L invested)
- Mid-career mass-affluent (₹5–20L investable, currently in FDs/LIC)
- Skeptics (have money but distrust mutual funds and stocks)
- Existing investors using competitor apps (Groww, Kuvera, ETMoney)

*5 example interview questions:*

1. "Walk me through how you decided where to put your savings last year. Start from the very beginning."
2. "Tell me about a time you tried to invest in something and stopped or backed out. Why?"
3. "Where do you currently keep money you don't immediately need? Why there?"
4. "Have you used any apps for investing? Which? What worked, what didn't?"
5. "Who do you talk to before making money decisions? What do they tell you?"

*Existing data to review first:*

- RBI/SEBI reports on demat account growth in Tier 2/3 cities (2023–2025).
- User reviews of Groww, Kuvera, Zerodha, ETMoney specifically from non-metro users (look at city tags).
- Competitor onboarding flows — sign up myself for each, note friction.
- Internal data: do we have any pilot users in Tier 2/3? What's their behavior?
- Reddit r/IndiaInvestments, Quora threads, YouTube comment sections in Hindi/Tamil/Telugu.

*"Yes, build" criteria:*

- At least 60% of interviewed users (across segments) explicitly describe pain points around current FDs/gold/MF apps.
- At least 8 interviewees would change behavior for a Hindi-/regional-language wealth product (committed, not hypothetical).
- Clear underserved JTBD identified: e.g., "I want a safe place that's better than FD but not as scary as direct stocks, in my own language."
- Reasonable market size estimate: 80M+ households in HHI ₹5–25L band (verify via NSO data).

"No, kill" criteria:

- Interviewees overwhelmingly satisfied with existing apps (low opportunity score).
- Underlying barriers are structural (KYC frustration, language UI) that we can't differentiate on.
- Better opportunity in adjacent segment (e.g., metro mass-affluent).

This shows a PM treating discovery as a structured process, not a vibes session.

## 3.15 AI Leverage in Discovery

This is one of the highest-impact uses of AI for PMs. Here are concrete workflows.

### Use case 1: Synthesizing interview transcripts at scale.

Workflow:

1. Record interviews (with consent), transcribe via Otter.ai, Fireflies, or similar.
2. Paste transcripts into Claude or ChatGPT.
3. Prompt: *"You are a senior product researcher. Synthesize these 10 interview transcripts. Produce: (1) the top 5 jobs users described; (2) the top 5 pains; (3) common patterns across users; (4) outliers worth investigating; (5) the 10 most representative quotes (with attribution). Be specific. Quote directly when relevant."*
4. Verify the output against your own notes from the calls. Don't trust blindly.

This used to take 2–3 days. Now: 1 hour, with you remaining the editor.

### Use case 2: Generating interview question banks.

Prompt: *"I'm researching [topic] with [user segment]. Generate 30 interview questions, all in past-tense / behavioral form (Mom Test rules). Group them by: workflow discovery, pain discovery, alternatives, willingness to pay, and emotional/social jobs. Avoid hypothetical, leading, or compound questions."*

You'll get a much richer set than you'd come up with alone. Pick the best 8–10 for each interview.

### Use case 3: Persona drafting from data.

Prompt: *"Based on these 12 interview synthesis bullets and these 4 quantitative findings, draft a structured persona including job context, daily workflow, tool ecosystem, frequent jobs, frustrations, and definition of personal success. Mark anything I should verify before treating it as final."*

### Use case 4: Survey question critique.

Prompt: *"Critique this survey. For each question: is it leading? hypothetical? compound? double-barreled? Suggest improvements following best practices in survey methodology."*

**Use case 5: JTBD reformulation.**

Prompt: *"Here's a feature request: [paste]. Rewrite this as a job-to-be-done statement using the structure 'When [situation], I want [motivation], so I can [outcome].' Then suggest 3 alternative solutions to the same job that aren't the literal feature."*

**Use case 6: Roleplay an interview.**

If you're new to interviewing, AI is a great practice partner. Prompt: *"Roleplay as a 38-year-old marketing manager at a mid-market SaaS company. Act realistically — be polite, sometimes give socially desirable answers, but also be willing to share frustrations if I ask the right way. I'll interview you for 20 minutes about your weekly workflow. After, give me feedback on which of my questions were good (per Mom Test) and which were leading or hypothetical."*

This is among the highest-ROI uses of AI in PM training.

**Use case 7: Competitive review synthesis.**

Prompt: *"I want to understand what users complain about for [competitor product]. Help me draft a structured summary based on: app store reviews, Reddit posts, Twitter, public forum threads. List the top 10 user complaints, with examples and frequency estimates. Note which complaints are repeated across sources."*

You can do the actual scraping with a browser or tools like Apify; AI does the synthesis. (Be mindful of terms of service for scraping.)

**Critical caveats:**

- AI synthesis can hallucinate quotes. Always verify a quote exists in the original source before using it externally.
- AI can over-smooth nuance. The richest insights are often outliers — look for them yourself.
- AI reflects biases in its training data. Don't trust it for emerging-market context as much as for US/EU context. Verify with primary research.

## 3.16 Comprehensive References for Part 3

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**Books:**

- *The Mom Test* — Rob Fitzpatrick. Short, brilliant, essential. Read it twice. ([Amazon](#))
- *Continuous Discovery Habits* — Teresa Torres. The most practical modern framework for ongoing user discovery. ([Amazon](#))
- *Jobs to Be Done: Theory to Practice* — Tony Ulwick. The Outcome-Driven Innovation method. ([Amazon](#))
- *Competing Against Luck* — Clayton Christensen. The original JTBD book. ([Amazon](#))
- *Demand-Side Sales 101* — Bob Moesta. The "Switch" interview technique for understanding why people change. ([Amazon](#))

- *Just Enough Research* — Erika Hall. A short, practical user research handbook. ([A Book Apart](#))
- *Interviewing Users* — Steve Portigal. The craft of qualitative interviews. ([Amazon](#))

### Essays / Articles:

- "How Superhuman Built an Engine to Find Product/Market Fit" — Rahul Vohra. ([First Round Review](#))
- "The Real Reason Users Hire Your Product" — Bob Moesta on JTBD. ([Re:Wired](#))
- "The Discovery Loop" — Teresa Torres. ([producttalk.org](#))
- "Don't Listen to Your Users" — Sahil Lavingia. (Provocative companion to Mom Test.)
- "12 Things About Product-Market Fit" — Tren Griffin / Andy Rachleff. ([a16z](#))

### Tools:

- **Recording / Transcription:** Otter.ai, Fireflies.ai, Grain, Descript. ([otter.ai](#), [fireflies.ai](#))
- **Scheduling user interviews:** Calendly, Cal.com.
- **Survey tools:** Typeform, Tally, Google Forms, SurveyMonkey, Maze.
- **Affinity mapping / synthesis:** Miro, FigJam, Mural, Dovetail (research-specific). ([dovetail.com](#))
- **User research panels (recruit users):** UserTesting, UserInterviews.com, Respondent.io.
- **Session recordings:** FullStory, Hotjar, LogRocket.

### Newsletters / Podcasts:

- Teresa Torres's *Product Talk* podcast and blog.
- Lenny's Newsletter — multiple deep-dives on discovery.
- Bob Moesta's podcast *The Re-Wired Group*.

### Free practice resources:

- Reforge's free articles on user research. ([reforge.com/blog](#))
- Indi Young's "Listening Deeply" — a free guide to deeper qualitative work. ([indiyoung.com](#))

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*End of Part 3 and Chunk 1. The next chunk covers product strategy, vision, and positioning (Part 4) and ideation/prioritization (Part 5). When you're ready to keep going, just say "continue." -e*

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